

Four conflicting versions of events



The bandit's version

- He tricked the samurai and tied him to a tree
- He seduced the samurai's wife, after initial resistance
- The wife convinced him to fight a duel with the samurai; he defeated him honorably

The samurai's version

- The bandit raped his wife; she chose to go with the bandit
- The bandit gave him a choice: let his wife go, or kill her as punishment for her infidelity
- His wife fled, followed by the bandit; he killed himself



The wife's version

- The bandit raped her
- She begged her husband to kill her to save her honor
- She fainted, holding the dagger, and awoke to find her husband dead

The woodcutter's version

- The bandit begged the samurai's wife to marry him; instead she freed the samurai
- The wife encouraged the bandit and the samurai to duel
- They duelled pathetically, and the bandit won by luck



on camera, divides the present from the past, which is sun-dappled in flashbacks. The forbidding gate symbolizes the viewer's gateway to the world of the movie, a realm in which nothing is what it seems and no one can be trusted.

The glade is also symbolic. We first see it through the woodcutter's eyes as he traipses deep into the forest at the beginning of the first flashback. In this beautiful, wordless sequence, Kurosawa

leads the viewer away from reality and into the febrile undergrowth of the subconscious; the forest clearing is an enchanted space in which the drama of the samurai's death will unfold again and again, each time in a different way.

Forests have always had a primal association with the human imagination—as dark places located far from civilization. In the traditional folklores of many cultures, forests are the sites of magical, inexplicable encounters. The earliest known Japanese prose narrative, *The Tale of the Bamboo Cutter*, also known as *Princess Kaguya*, is a 10th-century fable in which a lonely and childless woodsman stumbles across a phantasmal infant in the depths of a forest.

Kurosawa's movie reaches back to such folklore with its rural setting, its archetypal characters, and its notion that what we see is shaped unconsciously by our deepest fears and desires. The movie even features an abandoned child at the end, whom the woodsman takes home with him as the rain stops.

Embellishing stories

Kurosawa has said that humans cannot help embellishing stories about themselves, and this is what

“Just think. Which one of these stories do you believe?”

The commoner / Rashomon

Minute by minute

00:07

The woodcutter says that he was the first person to find the body of the samurai, and also the person who found Tajomaru.

00:17

At the inquest, Tajomaru tells his version of events, in which the wife begs him not to leave, and he cuts her husband loose so that they may fight for her honor.

00:51

The dead samurai tells his version through a medium. He says that his wife and Tajomaru ran off, and that he stabbed himself.

01:11

The woodcutter describes a desperate fight between the samurai and the bandit, in which both shake with fear.

00:00 00:15 00:30 00:45 01:00 01:15 01:28

00:12

The priest recounts how he saw the samurai before he died, leading a woman on a horse through the woods.

00:39

The wife tells her story. She says that she fainted, only to come round to find the dagger in her husband's chest. She then tried to drown herself.

01:03

At the gate, the woodcutter says that he saw everything. He says the husband did not want to fight, and wanted his wife to kill herself.

01:20

A baby is found crying at the gate. The woodcutter offers to take the baby home with him as the rain abates.